Lesson 08: Quotation Marks, Apostrophes, Parentheses, Hyphens and Capital Letters

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 8.4: Quotes; 8.5: Apostrophes; 8.6: Parentheses; 8.8: Hyphens; 8.9: Capitalization; 8.10: End-of-Chapter (Exercise).

In this lesson

You will learn to punctuate quotations and titles, use apostrophes, parentheses and hyphens, and follow the main rules for capital letters. Then you will review the whole chapter. These marks show whose words you are using and what belongs to whom, which is essential when you write about sources.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Punctuate direct quotations, quotations within quotations and titles, and tell direct from indirect quotations.
- Use apostrophes to show possession with singular and plural nouns and in contractions, and tell *it's* from *its*.
- Use parentheses for secondary information and hyphens for words that work as one adjective.
- Capitalize sentences, proper nouns, days, months, holidays and titles, but not common nouns.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
quotation marks (" ")	marks around a direct quotation (someone's exact words) or the title of a short work	Carly said, "I'm not ever going back there again."
indirect quotation	a report of someone's words, not exact; no quotation marks	Carly said that she would never go back there.
single quotation marks (' ')	marks for a quotation inside a quotation	"The instructions say, 'Tighten the screws one at a time.'"
apostrophe (')	a mark for possession (who or what owns something) or for missing letters	the dog's leash; don't
contraction	two words made into one, with an apostrophe for the missing letters; informal	we will = we'll
parentheses ( )	a pair of marks around secondary information	...the worst movie I have seen (so far).

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
hyphen (-)	a short mark that joins words working as one adjective, or divides a word at the end of a line	habit-forming
proper noun / common noun	the name of a particular person, place, thing or event (capital letter) / a general word (no capital)	Apollo Theater / theater

Rules and explanations

Quotation marks

- A **direct quotation** gives someone's exact words in quotation marks; an **indirect quotation** restates them without quotation marks.
- You can identify the speaker at the beginning, in the middle or at the end:

Position	Example
beginning	Madison said, "Let's stop at the farmers market to buy some fresh vegetables for dinner."
middle	"Let's stop at the farmers market," Madison said, "to buy some fresh vegetables for dinner."
end	"Let's stop at the farmers market to buy some fresh vegetables for dinner," Madison said.

- Capitalize the first word of a quoted sentence. When the speaker comes in the middle, the second part continues the same sentence, so it starts with a small letter. (A short phrase that fits into your own sentence also starts small, as in the next example.)
- Put a comma between the identifying words and the quotation. Commas and periods go **inside** the closing quotation marks. Question marks and exclamation points go inside only if they belong to the quoted words: The new employee asked, "When is lunch?" / Did you hear her say you were "the next Picasso"?
- A quotation inside a quotation takes single marks: Theresa said, "I wanted to take my dog to the festival, but the man at the gate said, 'No dogs allowed.'"
- **Titles:** quotation marks for short works (essays, songs, poems, short stories, chapters): "Annabel Lee" is one of my favorite romantic poems. (The book spells Poe's title "Annabelle Lee".) Long works (books, magazines, albums, newspapers, novels) are in italics when typed and underlined when handwritten: *The New York Times*.
- **Usage varies:** these are American rules. British writers often use single marks first, and put commas and periods outside the marks when they are not part of the quotation.

Apostrophes

Noun	Add	Example
singular (also when it ends in s; some writers add only ' here: Jess')	's	Jen's dance routine / Jess's sister
plural ending in s	'	The drummers' sticks
plural not ending in s	's	The people's votes

- In a **contraction**, the apostrophe shows where letters are missing: do not = don't; let us = let's. Contractions are used in informal writing, not in formal writing.
- *it's* = it is (or it has); *its* = belonging to it. Test: if "it is" makes sense, write *it's*. It's cold and rainy outside. / The cat was chasing its tail.

Parentheses

- Parentheses are always used in pairs and contain information that is secondary to the meaning of the sentence. The sentence must still make sense without the words in parentheses, so never put the subject or the verb of the sentence inside them.
- Your spinach and garlic salad is one of the most delicious (and nutritious) foods I have ever tasted!

Hyphens

- Join words that work together as one description: The fifty-five-year-old athlete was just as qualified for the marathon as his younger opponents. / it can be habit-forming / the mid-year review
- Divide a word between two syllables at the end of a line. If you are not sure where, check a dictionary or move the whole word to the next line.

Capital letters

(Pictures with some of these rules are missing from the lesson material.)

- Capitalize the first word of a sentence.
- Capitalize **proper nouns**: the names of specific people, places, objects, streets, buildings and events, and titles of individuals (Dr. Jackson, Uncle Javier).
- Always capitalize nationalities, races, languages and religions: American, African American, Hispanic, Muslim, Hindu, Buddhist.
- Capitalize days of the week, months and holidays.
- In titles of works, capitalize the first word and the important words; short words such as *a*, *the*, *and*, *of*, *on* and *to* stay small unless they come first: *Pride and Prejudice*.
- Do not capitalize a **common noun** used in a general way: museum / The Art Institute of Chicago; country / Malaysia; college / Smith College; historical event / The Renaissance.
- The book capitalizes *Internet*, but never *e-mail* or *online*. Many style guides now write *internet*.
- Whole words in capitals read like shouting; do not use them for emphasis.

Psychology note: in an APA reference list, article and chapter titles have no quotation marks, and only the first word, the first word after a colon and proper nouns are capitalized.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic script has no capital letters, so capitals are easy to forget. Check every name, nationality, language, religion, day and month (Monday, March, Arabic, Muslim) and the pronoun *I*.

Practice

The exercises have no numbers in the lesson material; here they are numbered in order. Exercises 7 and 8 are from the end-of-chapter exercises.

Exercise 1. Quotation marks. Add quotation marks where necessary. If a sentence needs none, write OK.

1. Yasmin said, I don't feel like cooking. Let's go out to eat.
2. Where should we go? said Russell.
3. Yasmin said it didn't matter to her.
4. I know, said Russell, let's go to the Two Roads Juice Bar.
5. Perfect! said Yasmin.
6. Did you know that the name of the Juice Bar is a reference to a poem? asked Russell.
7. I didn't! exclaimed Yasmin. Which poem?
8. The Road Not Taken, by Robert Frost Russell explained.
9. Oh! said Yasmin, Is that the one that starts with the line, Two roads diverged in a yellow wood?
10. That's the one said Russell.

Exercise 2. Apostrophes. Add apostrophes. If a sentence is correct, write OK. (Items 5 and 6 are printed on one line in the lesson material.)

1. "What a beautiful child! She has her mothers eyes."
2. My brothers wife is one of my best friends.
3. I couldnt believe it when I found out that I got the job!
4. My supervisors informed me that I wouldnt be able to take the days off.
5. Each of the students responses were unique.
6. Wont you please join me for dinner tonight?

Exercise 3. Parentheses. Add parentheses. If a sentence is clear as it is, write OK.

1. Are you going to the seminar this weekend I am?
2. I recommend that you try the sushi bar unless you don't like sushi.
3. I was able to solve the puzzle after taking a few moments to think about it.
4. Please complete the questionnaire at the end of this letter.
5. Has anyone besides me read the assignment?
6. Please be sure to circle not underline the correct answers.

Exercise 4. Proper nouns. Write five proper nouns for *musician* and five for *magazine* (like Nile River for *river*).

Exercise 5. Titles and names. Correct the capitalization.

1. The prince of england enjoys playing polo.
2. "Ode to a nightingale" is a sad poem.

3. My sister loves to read magazines such as the new yorker.
4. The house on Mango street is an excellent novel written by Sandra Cisneros.
5. My physician, dr. alvarez, always makes me feel comfortable in her office.

Exercise 6. Capitals in a paragraph. Correct the capitalization in the two paragraphs about David Grann's book in the lesson material (they begin "david grann's the lost City of Z").

Exercise 7. Punctuation review (end-of-chapter Punctuation Exercise 1, selected items). Correct each sentence, or write OK.

- Quotes 1. The invitations said that the wedding would be "outdoor casual."
- Quotes 2. "What exactly does 'outdoor casual' mean?" I asked the bride.
- Quotes 3. She told me to dress comfortably and wear shoes that do not sink into the ground.
- Apostrophes 1. On the day of the wedding, were going to rent a limo.
- Apostrophes 2. My brothers wife will make the arrangements.
- Apostrophes 3. Shes a great party organizer.
- Parentheses 1. On the day of the wedding, the bride looked more beautiful than ever and I've known her for fifteen years.
- Parentheses 2. All the details were perfect in my opinion.
- Hyphens 1. The groom danced with his new mother in law.
- Hyphens 2. It was a spectacular, fun filled day for everyone.

More items: lesson material, the rest of this exercise (a review of Lessons 06 and 07), Punctuation Exercises 2 to 4 and Capitalization Exercises 1 and 3. Your tutor can check them.

Exercise 8. Capitalization review (end-of-chapter Capitalization Exercise 2). Correct the capitalization.

1. Marc came to the united states from Uganda.
2. She has carefully planted several species of flowers from japan.
3. I am especially proud of the Sunflowers I planted.
4. This summer, Elizabeth is travelling to Montreal, quebec, canada.
5. I like to eat ethnic food such as ethiopian.

Speak with your tutor

- "Tell me a short story with dialogue in Live conversation. I will write three of the lines with quotation marks and paste them for you to check."
- "Give me ten phrases like 'the boys bikes' or 'the womens team'. I will add the apostrophes and say whether each noun is singular or plural."
- "Here is my summary of a PSYC 110 lecture, with one quotation: [paste]. Check my quotation marks, apostrophes and capitals."

Writing task

A one-page autobiography (the book's writing application). Write 250 to 350 words about the people, places, dates and events that shaped your life. You may focus on one theme, for example how you learned English, or a person who influenced your development (a PSYC 110 topic). Include a direct quotation (something someone said to you), a title, two possessive nouns, a hyphenated description and information in parentheses.

Checklist:

- Names, places, nationalities, languages, religions, days, months and holidays have capitals; common nouns (university, uncle, river) do not, unless they are part of a name.
- Titles have capitals on the first and important words; short works are in quotation marks, long works in italics.
- Direct quotations have quotation marks, with commas and periods inside; indirect quotations have none.
- Possessive nouns have 's or (plural ending in s) only '; simple plurals and *its* have no apostrophe.
- I used contractions only inside quotations, because this is formal writing.
- Each sentence with parentheses still makes sense without the words inside them.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

The book gives no key; these answers follow the book's rules.

Exercise 1

1. Yasmin said, "I don't feel like cooking. Let's go out to eat."
2. "Where should we go?" said Russell.
3. OK (an indirect quotation)
4. "I know," said Russell, "let's go to the Two Roads Juice Bar." (Because "I know" is a complete sentence, this is even better: "I know," said Russell. "Let's go ...")
5. "Perfect!" said Yasmin.
6. "Did you know that the name of the Juice Bar is a reference to a poem?" asked Russell.
7. "I didn't!" exclaimed Yasmin. "Which poem?"
8. "'The Road Not Taken,' by Robert Frost," Russell explained. (The poem's title is inside Russell's words, so it takes single marks.)
9. "Oh!" said Yasmin. "Is that the one that starts with the line, 'Two roads diverged in a yellow wood'?" (The question mark belongs to Yasmin's question, not to the poem, so it comes after the single mark. "Oh!" is complete, so a period after *Yasmin* is better than the comma in the lesson material.)
10. "That's the one," said Russell.

Exercise 2

1. mother's eyes
2. My brother's wife
3. couldn't
4. wouldn't (*supervisors* is a simple plural: no apostrophe)
5. Each of the students' responses was unique. (*students'* = of several students; *student's* if one student gave them all. *Each* needs a singular verb, so the book's *were* is a mistake.)
6. Won't

Exercise 3 (parentheses are partly the writer's choice)

1. Are you going to the seminar this weekend? (I am.) Or: ...this weekend (I am)?
2. ...try the sushi bar (unless you don't like sushi).
3. OK (parentheses are possible but not needed)
4. OK (the place of the questionnaire is important information)
5. Has anyone (besides me) read the assignment? (OK is also acceptable.)
6. ...circle (not underline) the correct answers.

Exercise 4 (example answers) Musicians: Ludwig van Beethoven, Fairuz, Bob Marley, Yo-Yo Ma, Taylor Swift. Magazines: *Time*, *National Geographic*, *Scientific American*, *Psychology Today*, *Vogue*.

Exercise 5

1. The Prince of England … (Some style guides keep *prince* small when no name follows.)
2. "Ode to a Nightingale"
3. *The New Yorker* (in italics when typed)
4. *The House on Mango Street*
5. Dr. Alvarez

Exercise 6 (the changed words)

- Paragraph 1: David Grann's *The Lost City of Z* … the Amazon River … three distinct stories … twists in the river … the author describes … to the Amazon … Percy Fawcett's voyage … The answer is one that both the author and the reader …
- Paragraph 2: the author, David Grann, is lost in the Amazon … Grann's experience. Grann has dropped … The suspense … himself a neutral witness …

Exercise 7

- Quotes 1-3: OK. All three are already correct (3 is an indirect quotation).
- Apostrophes: 1. we're 2. brother's 3. She's
- Parentheses: 1. …than ever (and I've known her for fifteen years). 2. All the details were perfect (in my opinion).
- Hyphens: 1. mother-in-law 2. fun-filled

Exercise 8

1. the United States
2. from Japan
3. the sunflowers
4. Montreal, Quebec, Canada (*travelling* is British spelling; American English writes *traveling*.)
5. Ethiopian

My notes